

WHAT'S THE WORD ON THE STREET ABOUT JESUS?

* Blue denotes power point slide

(JAY WALKING VIDEO - #1)

One day, as Jesus and His disciples were traveling through Caesarea Philippi, He asked His disciples a very telling question. *Matthew 16:13 (NKJV) "Who do men say that I, the Son of Man, am?"*

This encounter between Jesus and His disciples takes place near Caesarea Philippi, located fifteen miles north of the Sea of Galilee. Caesarea was originally named "Paneus" and was dedicated to the worship of the god "Pan". Pan was the god of the wild:

- The god of shepherds and flocks...
- The god of nature and mountains...
- The god of hunting and fishing...
- The god of rustic music...

The god, Pan, had the head, chest, and arms of a man; and the legs, horns, and ears of a goat. (This is your daughter's boyfriend's ancestors... I ran onto this guy in the mall a few days ago... Ugly is in...) Pan was believed to prance through the countryside playing his seven-reed pipe in wild abandon. At times his piping could be as soft and gentle as the breeze, but when he was angry, his bellow and howl was said to be heard for miles across the countryside.

As Jesus and His disciples passed through this area, they were no doubt confronted with countless images of Roman gods.

The countryside was littered with statues of idols to various gods. Historians tell us that there were fourteen temples to the god Baal in this region.

It is significant that Jesus took His disciples to this area, because it was here that it was believed that Baal entered through one of the many caves into Hades. This specific cave was known as *“The Gates of Hell.”*

It is against the backdrop of the Gates of Hell, surrounded by idols, that Jesus asks the question, *“What’s the word on the street about me?”*

The disciples gave an immediate answer:

- John the Baptist...
- Elijah...
- Jeremiah...
- One of the prophets...

The best-case scenario - the population believed Jesus was a contemporary of John the Baptist, or an ancient prophet come back from the dead.

What’s the word on the street about Jesus?

What famous people and magazine articles have said about Him:

- H. G. Wells – *“Jesus is the dominant figure in all of History.”*
- Ralph Waldo Emerson - *“The unique impression of Jesus upon mankind - whose name is not so much written as ploughed into the history of the world is proof of the subtle virtue of this infusion. Jesus belonged to the race of prophets. He saw with open eyes the mystery of the soul. One man was*

true to what is in you and me. He, as I think, is the only soul in history who has appreciated the worth of man.”

- Newsweek – March 1999 – In an article titled - “2,000 thousand years of Jesus” – *“Historians did not record his birth. Nor, for 30 years, did anyone pay him much heed. A Jew from the Galilean hill country with a reputation for teaching and healing, he showed up at the age of 33 in Jerusalem during Passover. In three days, he was arrested, tried and convicted of treason, then executed like the commonest of criminals. His followers said that God raised him from the dead. Except among those who believed in him, the event passed without notice. By any secular standard, Jesus is also the dominant figure of Western culture.”*
- U.S. News & World Report 1993 – *“Today, there is broad consensus among even the most skeptical of scholars that Jesus probably did perform feats that would have been perceived as miracles at that time.”*
- Michael Grant – *“The most potent figure, not only in the history of religion, but in world history as a whole, is Jesus Christ: the maker of one of the few revolutions which have lasted. Millions of men and women for century after century have found his life and teaching overwhelmingly significant and moving. And there is ample reason in this later twentieth century why this should still be so.”*
- Joseph M. Stowell – *“Hands down, Jesus has drawn more attention and interest than anyone who has ever breathed the air of this planet.”*

What’s the word on the street about Jesus?

(JAY WALKING VIDEO - #2)

What do other religions say about Him?

- Islam says – *“Jesus was born to Maryam as the result of virginal conception, a miraculous event which occurred by the decree of Allah. To aid in his ministry to the Jewish people, Jesus was given the ability to perform miracles such as healing the blind, bringing dead people back to life, all by the permission of Allah rather than of his own power. According to the Quran, Jesus, although appearing to have been crucified was not killed by crucifixion, or by any other means, instead, ‘God raised him unto Himself.’ Like all prophets in Islam, Jesus is considered to have been a Muslim, one who submits to the will of Allah. He preached that his followers should adopt the ‘straight path’ as commanded by Allah. Islam rejects the Trinitarian Christian view that Jesus was God incarnate or the Son of God. They deny that He was ever crucified or resurrected, or that he ever atoned for the sins of mankind. The Quran says that Jesus himself never claimed any of these things, and it furthermore indicates that Jesus will deny having ever claimed divinity at the Last Judgment, and that Allah will validate this. The Quran emphasizes that Jesus was a mortal human like all other prophets, being divinely chosen to spread God's message.”*
- Scientology says – *“Jesus is one, and only one, of many good teachers. Hubbard states in Volunteer Ministers Handbook: ‘Man is basically good but he could not attain expression of this until now. Nobody but the individual could die for his own sins, to arrange things otherwise was to keep man in chains.’”*
- Jehovah’s Witnesses say – *“Jesus Christ was a perfect man, and that He is a person distinct from God the Father. However; they also teach that before His earthly life, Jesus was a spirit creature, Michael the archangel, who was created by God and became the Messiah at His baptism. According to Jehovah’s Witnesses, Jesus is a mighty one, although not as almighty as Jehovah God is. According to*

John 1:1 in their Bible, The New World Translation, Christ is 'a god,' but not 'the God.' They teach that Jesus 'was, and is, and always will be, beneath Jehovah' and that 'Christ and God are not coequal.'"

- Mormonism says – *"God the Father has a body of flesh and bones and that Jesus is a creation who was begotten in heaven as one of God's spirit children. Mormon theology teaches that God is only one of countless gods, that he used to be a man on another planet, that he became a god by following the laws and ordinances of that god on that world, and that he brought one of his wives to this world, with whom he produces spirit children who then inhabited human bodies at birth. The first spirit child to be born was Jesus. Second was Satan, and then we all followed. Mormonism teaches that the sacrifice of Jesus on the cross itself, and receiving it by faith, is not sufficient to bring forgiveness of sins. It teaches that the forgiveness of sins is obtained through a cooperative effort with God; that is, we must be good and follow the laws and ordinances of the Mormon church in order to obtain forgiveness."*

What's the word on the street about Jesus?

(JAY WALKING VIDEO - #3)

Matthew 16:15 (NKJV) *"He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?"*

What was the word on the street about Jesus in the First Century church?

- John The Baptist – ***"He is mightier than I – I am not worthy to take his shoes off."***
- Peter – ***"You are the Christ the Son of the living God."***

- Peter at Pentecost – *“Jesus of Nazareth a God-man proven to be so by signs miracles and wonders.”*
- John – *“He is the Word of life.”*

What’s the word on the street about Jesus? Who did Jesus declare Himself to be?

- A predecessor of Abraham – *“Before Abraham was, I am.”*
- An equal with God – *“I and my Father are one.”*
- The Lord of Glory – *“You have called me Lord, and you say well, for I am.”*
- The fulfillment of all Messianic prophecies – *“The woman said to Him, ‘I know that Messiah is coming. When He comes, He will tell us all things.’ Jesus said to her, ‘I who speak to you am He.’”*
- The only way to Heaven – *“I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father but by me.”*
- The Bread of Life - *“The bread of God is He who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world.”*
- The Light of the World - *“I am the light of the world. He who follows Me shall not walk in darkness, but have the light of life.”*
- The giver of eternal life - *“I give them eternal life.”*

What’s the word on the street about Jesus? Here is who I say He is:

- He is the first and last, the beginning and the end!
- He is the keeper of creation and the creator of all!
- He is the architect of the universe and the manager of all times!
- He always was, He always is, and He always will be!
- He is unmoved, unchanged, undefeated, and never undone!
- He is risen, and brings power and peace beyond comprehension!
- He is light, love, longevity, and Lord!

- He is goodness, kindness, gentleness, and God!
- He is holy, righteous, mighty, powerful, and pure!
- His ways are right, His word is eternal, His will is unchanging, and His mind is on me!
- He is the wisdom of the wise!
- He is the power of the powerful!
- He is the ruler of the rulers!
- He is the leader of the leaders!
- He is the overseer of the over-comers!
- He is the ancient of days!
- He is the Sovereign Lord of all that was and is and is to come!
- He is my Redeemer!
- He is my Savior!
- He is my guide!
- He is my peace!
- He is my Joy!
- He is my comfort!
- He is my Lord!
- He is the ruler of my life!

CONCLUSION:

What's the word on the street about Jesus? Who is He to you?

I can tell you this; His goal is a relationship with you. If you will enter into relationship with Him:

- He will never leave you!
- He will never mislead you!
- He will never forsake you!
- He will never forget you!
- He will never overlook you!
- He will never cancel your appointment in HIS appointment book!

- When you fall, He will lift you up!
- When you fail, He will forgive you!
- When you are weak, He will be strong!
- When you are lost, He will show you the Way!
- When you are afraid, He will be your protector!
- When you stumble, He will steady you!
- When you are broken, He will mend you!
- When you are hungry, He will feed you!

He is everything for everybody, everywhere, every time, and every way. He is Jesus! He is faithful! I am His, and He is mine!